

Active Directory / GPO request — email template

Fill the `<PLACEHOLDERS>`, delete the italic notes, pick **one** delivery mechanism (Registry is recommended), and send.

Why this is needed: Claude Code only offers the "Cloud gateway" login option when a specific setting is present in an admin-controlled machine-policy source. It is honored ONLY from a managed source — never from a developer's own settings — so it must be delivered by GPO (or MDM). Without it, the gateway login does not appear in the app at all. This is one small static value (the gateway URL), set once. This is Anthropic's design, not a limitation of our deployment.

To: Active Directory / Group Policy administrators (Windows endpoint / Intune team) **Cc:** \<project lead>, \<security/ATO contact> **Subject:** GPO request — Claude Code gateway-login policy for developer workstations

Hi team,

We're rolling out **Claude Code** (Anthropic's coding CLI) to developers, pointed at our internal Claude apps gateway in AWS GovCloud. The binary installs per-user with **no admin rights**, but the **gateway login itself requires one machine-policy setting** that only an administrator can deliver. Without it, the "Cloud gateway" option does not appear in the app's login menu — by Anthropic's design (it stops a user from being tricked into signing in at an arbitrary or hostile "gateway" URL that would harvest their corporate SSO).

We need a GPO that sets the value below on the developer workstations. It is a single static value — no per-user data, nothing time-varying (it changes only if the gateway URL itself changes).

1. What to set

Claude Code reads a JSON "managed settings" object. We need this object delivered (substitute our gateway FQDN):

```
{
  "forceLoginMethod": "gateway",
  "forceLoginGatewayUrl": "https://<GATEWAY_FQDN>",
  "forceRemoteSettingsRefresh": true,
  "parentSettingsBehavior": "merge"
}
```

- `<GATEWAY_FQDN>` = `<claude-gateway.example.com>` — our internal gateway (final value from the platform team; the name can be reserved now).

There are two supported delivery mechanisms. **Please use Mechanism A (Registry) unless you specifically prefer file distribution** — it is one value, no file staging, and no text-encoding pitfalls.

Mechanism A — GPP Registry item (*recommended*)

- **GPO path:** Computer Configuration → Preferences → Windows Settings → **Registry**
- **Action:** Update
- **Hive:** HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE
- **Key path:** SOFTWARE\Policies\ClaudeCode
- **Value name:** Settings
- **Value type:** REG_SZ
- **Value data** (single line, substitute the FQDN):

```
{"forceLoginMethod":"gateway", "forceLoginGatewayUrl":"https://  
<GATEWAY_FQDN>", "forceRemoteSettingsRefresh":true, "parentSettingsBehavior":"merge"}
```

Machine scope (Computer Configuration) so it applies to any user who signs on. Use **Update** (not Replace) so the item refreshes in place each policy cycle without churn.

Mechanism B — GPP Files item (*alternative*)

- Stage a file `managed-settings.json` (containing the JSON object above) on a share every workstation can read, e.g. `\<fileserver>\<share>\ClaudeCode\managed-settings.json`. **The share must grant read to Domain Computers / machine accounts:** a Computer-Configuration GPP Files copy runs as **SYSTEM** and authenticates to the UNC path as the *machine* account, not the logged-on user (the classic GPP-Files failure mode — another reason we prefer Mechanism A).
- **GPO path:** Computer Configuration → Preferences → Windows Settings → **Files**
- **Action:** Update · **Source:** the UNC path above · **Destination:** `%ProgramFiles%\ClaudeCode\managed-settings.json`
- **File encoding — important:** the JSON file must be **UTF-8 without a BOM**. Claude Code rejects a byte-order-marked JSON file, and many Windows editors (and PowerShell 5.1's `Set-Content -Encoding UTF8`) add a BOM by default. Save as "UTF-8" / "UTF-8 (no BOM)", not "UTF-8 with BOM". (*This encoding trap is exactly why we prefer Mechanism A.*)
- The destination is `%ProgramFiles%` (admin-write-only — that is the point; it's tamper-resistant). Note Claude Code moved this path from `%ProgramData%` in a recent version, so please use `%ProgramFiles%`.

2. Targeting / scope

- Apply to the OU (or security group) holding the developer workstations: `<OU_OR_SECURITY_GROUP>`.

- **Computer Configuration** (machine policy) — applies regardless of which user logs on.
 - Clients pick it up on the next Group Policy refresh (or `gpupdate /force`).
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3. Why it must be machine policy (not a user setting)

- Claude Code honors `forceLoginMethod` / `forceLoginGatewayUrl` **only** from an administrator-controlled source — machine registry policy (HKLM), a machine `managed-settings.json`, or a macOS managed preference. A value a developer places in their own profile (`HKCU`, `%USERPROFILE%\\.claude\settings.json`) is **ignored**. So a non-admin fleet cannot self-serve this; it must be a GPO.
 - **The design reason (worth stating to the reviewer):** the gateway terminates the developer's Okta SSO. If any user could point the CLI at an arbitrary gateway URL, that would be a credential-phishing / MITM vector. Requiring an admin-vetted URL closes it.
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4. What each key does

- `forceLoginMethod`: "gateway" — makes the CLI use (and only offer) the gateway login; this is what causes the "Cloud gateway" option to exist and be pre-selected.
- `forceLoginGatewayUrl` — the gateway URL, pre-filled on the login screen so developers never type it (they press Enter to connect).
- `forceRemoteSettingsRefresh`: `true` — the CLI **blocks startup until it has freshly fetched the gateway's managed settings, and exits if that fetch fails**. This is what guarantees the gateway's central policy actually reaches the client. Without it, a laptop that cannot reach the gateway starts anyway with **no** gateway policy applied — which means the model allowlist is absent and Claude Code falls back to its own built-in model menu, none of whose entries our gateway serves.

Trade-off, stated plainly: this converts a gateway or network outage from "Claude Code runs with an unrestricted model menu" into "Claude Code will not start". Since the gateway is already a hard dependency for inference, this mostly makes an existing dependency honest rather than adding a new one — but it does remove any offline grace period. Drop this key if you would rather developers retain a (non-functional for inference) CLI during an outage. -

`parentSettingsBehavior`: "merge" — *(optional; harmless to include)* controls whether managed settings supplied by an **embedding process via the SDK** (`Options.managedSettings` / `--managed-settings`, e.g. Claude Desktop or an IDE extension launching Claude Code) layer underneath this admin policy tier. `first-wins` (the default) drops them entirely. It has no effect on the gateway's own `/managed/settings` push, and no effect at all on machines where developers just run `claude` and sign in. - Do **not** include `requiredMinimumVersion` — the gateway pushes the client version floor itself (defaulting to the gateway's own version), so a GPO-pinned copy is redundant and risks disagreeing with the pushed value.

5. Confirming it worked

On a test workstation after the GPO applies (`gpupdate /force`):

- A developer runs `c:\cmd\cmd.exe`, then `gpupdate /status`. The "setting sources" should list the **managed (policy)** source, with `forceLoginMethod` shown as coming from it.
 - Running `c:\cmd\cmd.exe` should go **straight to the gateway login** — no menu, URL pre-filled — and open the browser for a one-time **Okta** sign-in.
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6. Notes

- No per-user data; one static value. It changes only if the gateway FQDN changes — and any change is a one-line GPO edit.
- This composes with, and is separate from, the enterprise-CA trust and Zscaler asks in [networking-request-email.md](#), and the Okta app in [okta-request-email.md](#) (the SSO the gateway login uses).
- We can provide a test workstation and the exact `<GATEWAY_FQDN>` value, and are happy to jump on a call.

Thanks, \<name / team>